

A true pioneer, Marie Curie was a passionate and dedicated scientist whose work on radioactivity opened up a whole new world of knowledge. She discovered two new radioactive elements and laid the groundwork for the use of radiotherapy in the treatment of cancer.

Marie Curie was born Maria Skłodowska in Warsaw, Poland. Her life was hard from the start: by the age of 10, both her mother and her eldest sister had died. Although she was very bright, women in Poland at that time were not allowed to attend college, so Marie studied in secret while working as a governess. By the time she was 23, she had saved enough money to go to college at the Sorbonne, in Paris. There, she earned degrees in both physics and mathematical sciences, and also met and married the physicist Pierre Curie. The pair made a brilliant team.

Fascinated by the recent discovery by Henri Becquerel that some chemical elements were radioactive, Curie decided to pursue research in this field herself, and Pierre joined her. They worked tirelessly in the analysis of uranium ore (known as pitchblende) and, in 1898, identified two new radioactive elements within it: polonium (named after Curie's native Poland) and radium. The discovery earned them the 1903 Nobel Prize in Physics, which was awarded to the Curies and to Becquerel.

Fascinated by his wife's work, Pierre abandoned his own research to join Curie in hers. Together, they published a series of landmark joint papers.

MILESTONES

NEW ELEMENTS

Discovers two new radioactive elements with her husband in 1898: polonium and radium.

ATOMIC PHYSICS

Creates a new field of study, atomic physics, and coins the word "radioactivity" in 1898.

NOBEL PRIZE

Awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics for her and her husband's "extraordinary services" in 1903.

CANCER TREATMENT

Works with French chemist André-Louis Debierne to isolate radium in 1910, later used in radiotherapy.

WINS AGAIN

Makes history as the first person to be awarded two Nobels by winning the chemistry prize in 1911.

